Alexander and the Terrible, Horrible, No Good, Very Bad Day

By Judith Viorst

INTRODUCTION

Ever had one of those days or a day when lots of "THOSE DAYS" gang up on your all at onece? Alexander is only 8, but today, he's faced a barrage of bummers worthy of a country- western song: getting smushed in the middle seat of the car, a dessert-less lunch sack, a cavity at the dentist's office, stripe-less sneakers, witnessing kissing on television, and being forced to sleep in railroad-train pajamas. When it comes right down to it . . . it's all in your perspective.

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ALEXANDER: I went to sleep with gum in my mouth and now there's gum in my hair and when I got out of bed this morning I tripped on the skateboard and by mistake I dropped my sweater in the sink while the water was running and I could tell it was going to be a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

At breakfast Anthony found a Corvette Sting Ray car kit in his breakfast cereal box and Nick found a Junior Undercover Agent code ring in his breakfast cereal box but in my breakfast cereal box all I found was breakfast cereal. I think I'll move to Australia.

In the carpool, Mrs. Gibson let Becky have a seat by the window. Audrey and Elliott got seats by the window too. I said I was being scrunched. I said I was being smushed. I said, if I don't get a seat by the window, I am going to be car sick. No one even answered. I could tell it was going to be a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

At school Mrs. Dickens liked Paul's picture of the sailboat better than my picture of the invisible castle. At singing time, she said I sang too loud. At counting time, she said I left

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out sixteen. Who needs sixteen? I could tell it was going to be a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

I could tell because Paul said I wasn't his best friend anymore. He said that Phillip Parker was his best friend, and that Albert Moyo was his next best friend and that I was only his third best friend. I hope you sit on a tack, I said to Paul. I hope the next time you get a double-decker strawberry ice cream cone the ice cream part falls off the cone part and lands in Australia.

There were two cupcakes in Phillip Parker's lunch bag and Albert got a Hershey bar with almonds and Paul's mother gave him a piece of jelly roll that had little coconut sprinkles on the top. Guess whose mother forgot to put in dessert? It was a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

That's what it was, because after school, my mom took us all to the dentist and Dr. Fields found a cavity just in me. "Come back next week and I'll fix it," said Dr. Fields. "Next week," I said, "I'm going to Australia."

On the way downstairs the elevator door closed on my foot and while we were waiting for my mom to go get the car, Anthony made me fall where it was muddy and then when I started crying because of the mud, Nick said I was a crybaby and while I was punching Nick for saying "crybaby," my mom came back with the car and scolded me for being muddy and fighting. I am having a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

I told everybody. No one even answered. So then we went to the shoe store to buy some sneakers. Anthony chose white ones with blue stripes. Nick chose red ones with white stripes. I chose blue ones with red stripes, but the man said, "We're all sold out." They made me buy plain old white ones, but they can't make me wear them.

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When we picked up my dad at his office, he said I couldn't play with his copying machine, but I forgot. He also said to watch out for his books on his desk and I was careful as could be except for my elbow. He also said don't fool around with his phone, but I think I called Australia. My dad said please don't pick him up anymore. It was a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

There were lima beans for dinner, and I hate limas. There was kissing on TV, and I hate kissing. My bath was too hot, I got soap in my eyes, my marble went down the drain, and I had to wear my railroad-train pajamas. I hate my railroad-train pajamas. When I went to bed, Nick took back the pillow he said I could keep, and the Mickey Mouse night-light burned out and I bit my tongue. The cat wants to sleep with Anthony, not with me. It has been a terrible, horrible, no good, very bad day.

My mom says some days are like that even in Australia.

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